

History of English Literature - Important MCQs

Page 10 - Introductory (Part 1)

Q1. According to the text, a history of English literature is fundamentally an account of what?

- A. Chronological books and their authors
- B. The evolution of English grammar
- C. Important political events
- D. The history of printing presses

Answer: A

Q2. What does every book immediately take us back to, according to the text?

- A. The historical era it was written in
- B. The man behind it
- C. The publisher of the book
- D. The society of the time

Answer: B

Q3. In a history of English literature, what must we fix attention upon?

- A. The economic background of the era
- B. The personalities of the men who made the literature
- C. The linguistic changes over time
- D. The structural composition of the texts

Answer: B

Q4. What is a key limitation mentioned regarding a short sketch of literature history?

- A. It cannot list every single book published.
- B. It cannot examine in detail the authors' lives, experiences, and characters.
- C. It cannot explain poetic meters.
- D. It cannot cover more than one century.

Answer: B

Q5. According to the text, what does 'genius' fundamentally mean?

- A. High intelligence quotient
- B. Strength of personality and originality

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C. The ability to write rapidly

D. Knowing many languages

Answer: B

Q6. Why is it important to understand the distinctive quality of an author's genius?

A. To know how much money they made

B. To understand how they lived their personal lives

C. To appreciate the reason they are studied in a historical survey

D. To guess their political affiliation

Answer: C

Q7. How does the text describe the initial, obvious answer to 'What is a history of English literature?'

A. Perfect and comprehensive

B. Completely incorrect

C. All right as far as it goes, but too vague

D. Too detailed and complex

Answer: C

Q8. What does every book embody, aside from being a product of genius?

A. The thoughts and feelings of its author

B. The exact events of the time

C. A hidden political message

D. The collective voice of the people

Answer: A

Q9. In examining authors, what must be left for a more extended study?

A. The titles of their books

B. Detailed examinations of their lives and characters

C. The chronological order of their works

D. The genres they wrote in

Answer: B

Q10. What is the consequence of strength of personality in a writer?

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- A. Wealth
- B. Originality
- C. Controversy
- D. Anonymity

Answer: B

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Q1. What is the one absolutely new thing every great writer brings into the world?

- A. A new vocabulary
- B. Himself
- C. A new literary genre
- D. A different political view

Answer: B

Q2. Why does an author's work bear its own special hallmark?

- A. Because of the publisher's branding
- B. Because they put their own personality into what they write
- C. Because they follow strict literary rules
- D. Because they write anonymously

Answer: B

Q3. What does a mere list of authors and their books fail to constitute?

- A. A bibliography
- B. A catalog
- C. A history of literature
- D. An index

Answer: C

Q4. How does literature as a whole behave from generation to generation?

- A. It remains stagnant
- B. It is forgotten
- C. It grows and changes
- D. It repeats itself perfectly

Answer: C

Q5. What happens when a writer's exceptionally powerful personality influences others?

- A. They are banned from publishing
- B. They reveal his influence in their thought and style

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- C. They stop writing
- D. They create completely different works

Answer: B

Q6. How are literary 'schools' and 'movements' typically formed?

- A. By government decree
- B. Through the success and imitation of a particular kind of work
- C. By critics demanding new styles
- D. By pure coincidence

Answer: B

Q7. What does the 'school' of Pope refer to?

- A. A physical building where Pope taught
- B. A succession of poets who wrote in Pope's specific style
- C. A group of philosophers
- D. A religious institution

Answer: B

Q8. Which writer is credited with providing the principal impulse for the 'romantic' movement in prose fiction?

- A. Pope
- B. Spenser
- C. Scott
- D. Shakespeare

Answer: C

Q9. What must be remembered about even the most original men?

- A. They never read other authors' works
- B. They have their intellectual ancestry and are indebted to others
- C. They are always popular in their lifetime
- D. They always reject previous styles

Answer: B

Q10. What was the 'classic' movement in verse?

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- A. A movement that rejected Pope's style
- B. A movement that carried on Pope's lead in verse
- C. A movement inspired by Scott's novels
- D. A movement that focused on ancient Greek texts

Answer: B

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Page 12 - Introductory (Part 3)

Q1. Whose movement in verse was Alexander Pope carrying to perfection?

- A. Shakespeare's
- B. Scott's
- C. Spenser's
- D. Dryden's

Answer: D

Q2. Before Scott became a supreme master in his literary school, what school was he educated in?

- A. The classic school
- B. The romantic school
- C. The realist school
- D. The modernist school

Answer: B

Q3. How is Shakespeare's entry into drama described?

- A. He invented the drama of his day entirely from scratch.
- B. He took the drama up at the point it had reached and followed his forerunners' lines.
- C. He completely rejected all past dramatic forms.
- D. He only wrote prose fiction before turning to drama.

Answer: B

Q4. What is the central purpose of a history of literature, according to the text?

- A. To list every author's biography
- B. To give a clear account of the transformation of literature from period to period
- C. To rank authors by greatness
- D. To critique the personal lives of writers

Answer: B

Q5. How do the prevailing tastes of one age usually compare to those of another age?

- A. They are identical
- B. They are slightly different

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C. They are sure to differ, often enormously

D. They cycle predictably every decade

Answer: C

Q6. How does the text describe the literature of the great Victorian era in relation to today?

A. It is entirely identical to modern literature

B. Much of it now seems as foreign to us as its fashions in dress

C. It is completely lost and unreadable

D. It is the only literature worth studying

Answer: B

Q7. In Spenser's day, there was boundless enthusiasm for which work?

A. The Lady of the Lake

B. Essay on Man

C. The Faery Queene

D. Hamlet

Answer: C

Q8. In Pope's day, which work garnered boundless enthusiasm?

A. The Faery Queene

B. Essay on Man

C. The Lady of the Lake

D. Lyrical Ballads

Answer: B

Q9. What must we be careful NOT to do when considering the influence of individual men?

A. Give full weight to personal initiative

B. Emphasize their importance to the exclusion of all other considerations

C. Recognize their impact on literature

D. Note their intellectual ancestry

Answer: B

Q10. By what is even the greatest genius necessarily moulded?

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- A. Only by their own thoughts
- B. By the culture, ideals, and mental life of their time
- C. By the royal decree of their era
- D. By the geographical location of their birth

Answer: B